

Middle East Daily Brief

July 8, 2026

Executive summary

8 stories from 6 outlets (5 perspectives) over the reporting window. Leading the day: US launches 'powerful strikes' on Iran after tankers attacked in Strait of Hormuz; Tehran threatens to halt talks.

Top stories

1. **US launches 'powerful strikes' on Iran after tankers attacked in Strait of Hormuz; Tehran threatens to halt talks** *Al Jazeera, BBC, Bloomberg, CBS News, CNBC, CNN, NPR, Reuters, The Jerusalem Post, The Times of Israel, The Washington Post, Time* · corroborated by 12 outlets US Central Command said it launched 'a series of powerful strikes' against Iran after at least three commercial vessels were attacked in and around the Strait of Hormuz, testing the fragile ceasefire that ended the 2026 war. Iranian state... <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/7/7/ships-attacked-in-the-strait-of-hormuz-what-that-means-for-ongoing-talks>
2. **Explosions wound at least 18 in Damascus during Macron's visit to Syria** *Al-Monitor, Al Jazeera, BBC, CNN, Euronews, Fox News, NPR, PBS* · corroborated by 8 outlets Two explosive devices, one placed in a rubbish bin and one in a parked car, detonated near Syria's tourism ministry and a hotel where French President Emmanuel Macron was expected to stay, wounding at least 18 people including four police... <https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2026/07/two-explosions-hit-damascus-macron-visits-syria>
3. **Saudi Arabia and Qatar say Iran struck their tankers in Strait of Hormuz** *Al Arabiya, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CNN, NPR, Reuters* · corroborated by 6 outlets Saudi Arabia's Foreign Ministry said Iran attacked its crude carrier Wedyan as it transited the Strait of Hormuz, while Qatar said its LNG tanker al-Rakiyat was hit while 'passing near' the waterway; a US official said three vessels were... <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east>
4. **Khamenei's coffin heads toward July 9 Mashhad burial as new supreme leader stays hidden** *BBC, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CNN, The Jerusalem Post, Time* · corroborated by 6 outlets Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's coffin was carried through Qom and toward the Shia shrine cities of Najaf and Karbala in Iraq during the final days of a six-day state funeral, ahead of burial on July 9 at the Imam Reza shrine in Mashhad. New... <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c07yy3j3nljo>
5. **Rights groups demand release of detained Gaza doctor Abu Safiya as lawyer reports severe beatings** *The National, Amnesty International, BBC, Democracy Now, Middle East Eye* · corroborated by 5 outlets A UN human rights body and Amnesty International demanded Israel release detained Gaza paediatrician Dr Hussam Abu Safiya, as his lawyer said the former Kamal Adwan Hospital director had been beaten so badly at the underground Rakevet... <https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/mena/2026/07/06/un-rights-body-calls-on-israel-to-release-gaza-doctor-hussam-abu-safiya/>
6. **Israeli police open probe after officer filmed throwing stun grenade into car in West Bank** *BBC, Middle East Monitor, The Times of Israel* · corroborated by 3 outlets Israeli police said they had opened an investigation after an officer was filmed throwing a stun grenade into a car

during an incident in the occupied West Bank, stating the officer had acted 'not in accordance with procedure.' The... <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c1eyyy18ye0o>

By theme

Israel – Gaza & the Palestinians

- **Rights groups demand release of detained Gaza doctor Abu Safiya as lawyer reports severe beatings** – The National, Amnesty International, BBC, Democracy Now, Middle East Eye <https://www.thenationalnews.com/news/mena/2026/07/06/un-rights-body-calls-on-israel-to-release-gaza-doctor-hussam-abu-safiya/>
- **Israeli police open probe after officer filmed throwing stun grenade into car in West Bank** – BBC, Middle East Monitor, The Times of Israel <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c1eyyy18ye0o>

Iran & the US

- **US launches 'powerful strikes' on Iran after tankers attacked in Strait of Hormuz; Tehran threatens to halt talks** – Al Jazeera, BBC, Bloomberg, CBS News, CNBC, CNN, NPR, Reuters, The Jerusalem Post, The Times of Israel, The Washington Post, Time <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2026/7/7/ships-attacked-in-the-strait-of-hormuz-what-that-means-for-ongoing-talks>
- **Khamenei's coffin heads toward July 9 Mashhad burial as new supreme leader stays hidden** – BBC, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CNN, The Jerusalem Post, Time <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/c07yy3j3n>

Syria & Iraq

- **Explosions wound at least 18 in Damascus during Macron's visit to Syria** – Al-Monitor, Al Jazeera, BBC, CNN, Euronews, Fox News, NPR, PBS <https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2026/07/two-explosions-hit-damascus-macron-visits-syria>
- **Ex-Syrian intelligence chief convicted of torture and sexual abuse by Austrian court** – BBC <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cy8ddd1m3mpo>

Gulf & Arabian Peninsula

- **Saudi Arabia and Qatar say Iran struck their tankers in Strait of Hormuz** – Al Arabiya, Al Jazeera, Arab News, CNN, NPR, Reuters <https://english.alarabiya.net/News/middle-east>

Israel – politics & society

- **Netanyahu says he and Trump are 'set on same goal' on Iran, warns against F-35s for Turkey** – The Times of Israel, The Jerusalem Post <https://www.timesofisrael.com/liveblog-july-7-2026/>

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